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INDIA'S BEST-EVER WOMAN BADMINTON PLAYER SAINA NEHWAL (ABOVE) MADE BIG STRIDES; JEEV MILKHA SINGH (RIGHT) WON FOUR EVENTS IN 2008

Singh, who won titles on the European, Japanese and Asian tours, had the best-ever finish by an Indian in a major (tied ninth in the PGA Championship) and was the first man to clean up a million dollars on the Asian Tour. He feels he is 'ready' to win a major and when a well-travelled pioneer like Jeev looks ahead no territory seems unconquerable.

As the year trailed off, an uneasy twilight set in. A gov-

ernment ruling has banned anyone holding an overseas citizenship from representing India, the ruling logical in a way. There is a quartet of players of Indian extraction who have won tennis titles and medals for the country and are the most directly affected by this ruling. But the silence is disturbing. Today no one—not one official, former player, teammate—is willing to speak in their favour at this switch in the rules. It's as if Indian tennis wants Prakash Amritraj, Shikha and Neha Uberoi and Sunitha Rao to be erased from their collective memory.

The cricketers—an intoxicating brew of experience and bravado, wisdom and energy—dream and speak of world domination. Yet they chose to sign off a dazzling year like careful accountants doing the maths, rather than with a flourish of intent. Thousands of miles away, South Africa held Australia by its throat, determined to stamp its ascendancy on the game with more emphasis than India did against England. When they re-group in a little under two months, India will travel to the one country

where they have not won a Test since 1976. New Zealand may be at the bottom of the Test table and at the bottom of the world, but at home, they are stubborn opponents and their wickets usually give India's finest an attack of the yips. Since 2001, India have won Tests on every single tour—except in the land of the Long White Cloud. Such a confluence of circumstances means that Dhoni's men must acclimatise at this suitably-trying base camp on their way to their eventual destination—the summit of world cricket. It will be a revealing tour.

As 2009 begins, it will carry with it some unchanging truths. Beijing has transformed the mind of the Indian athlete but not his life. Our structures remain antiquated, its custodians self-obsessed. It is why hockey has decayed, why weightlifting has politicked itself into irrelevance. The sports that broke away in Beijing—particularly mass sports like boxing and wrestling—must remember that the law that applies to athletes applies to them as well. If they do not perform, they will perish. ■



INDIA'S FINAL FRONTIER: In March-April, India tour New Zealand, where they have not won a Test since 1976.

THE T20 WORLD CUP: A world title that is India's to defend along with a growing reputation as the team to beat. It happens in June 2009.

JEEV'S CHARGE: The Asian Tour's first million-dollar man, India's No. 1 golfer Jeev Milkha Singh says he's ready to win a major.

THE ASCENT OF SAINA: Already India's best female player ever, Nehwal will play the world championships at home in Hyderabad.

THE RETURN OF SANIA: Ms Mirza returns to the tennis tour after an injury-ridden year broke her stride.

things to
look forward to